

In the two centuries since European colonisation, many exotic animals have been introduced to Australia. Some introduced species, like rabbits and foxes, have become established and invasive over time with no prospect of eradication.

The [Australian Bureau of Agricultural and Resources Economics and Sciences \(ABARES\)](#) estimates that vertebrate pest animals cost Australian farmers almost [\\$1 billion a year](#). On top of this, pest animals impact our natural environment, communities, places of cultural significance and infrastructure.

Shared responsibility

Managing pests protects our natural assets, like our soils, forests, biodiversity and waterways. It also protects our agriculture industries such as grazing, cropping and forestry. It is a shared responsibility. Farmers, industry, communities and governments all play a role.

We collaborate with the Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water ([DCCEEW](#)), state and territory environment and agriculture agencies, industry and community organisations. Together, we build the capacity of land managers and communities to manage pests.

Priority pest animals

We help land managers to reduce the impacts of feral pigs, feral deer, wild dogs, foxes and feral cats and wild rabbits.

We do this by providing funding for national coordination programs. These support effective, coordinated and humane best-practice management. This protects agricultural, environmental, social and cultural assets.

We also co-invest in projects for some of these pests through the [Supporting Communities Manage Pest Animals and Weeds Program](#).

National coordination programs

European wild rabbits

European rabbits cost Australia's agricultural sector up to \$197 million per year in control costs and agricultural losses. Rabbits consume crops and vegetation cover, out compete native species and remove critical habitat. The rabbit is the most cited invasive species affecting our threatened native species.

The department co-funds CISS to deliver the national wild rabbit management program. This initial commenced in late 2024. CISS host the National Rabbit Management Coordinator, Dr Heidi Kleinert. Dr Kleinert enhances land managers' capacity to apply humane, effective, and sustainable rabbit control techniques.

2026 Wild Rabbit Roundtable

On 10 June 2026, the Department convened a wild rabbit roundtable with state and territory governments, researchers, industry and NGOs.

Over 50 participants joined the online event to discuss progress against [Australia's Rabbit Biocontrol Pipeline Strategy](#), designed to achieve long-term sustainable rabbit control. The Roundtable also focused on supporting landholders to proactively manage rabbits.

While existing rabbit viruses are still working, effectiveness of rabbit biocontrol reduces over time as the viruses and rabbits evolve together. Ongoing research, monitoring and proactive integrated management is essential to manage rabbits in Australia.

The next phase of rabbit biocontrol research is underway. The Centre for Invasive Species (CISS), CSIRO, governments and Meat and Livestock Australia are finalising arrangements for the Future proofing rabbit biocontrol program Phase I (also known as RHD Accelerator). The group noted the importance of this research that will run to 2028-29.

Landholders are being supported to proactively manage rabbits (by governments, industry, NGO's and the national coordinator) to keep downward pressure on populations.

It was agreed to enhance governance and communications on delivery against the Rabbit Biocontrol Pipeline Strategy (including publishing an annual update) and pursue opportunities to extend the national rabbit management coordination program; enhance the national rabbit disease monitoring program to monitor rabbit abundance and serology over representative bioregions; and improve effectiveness of the RHDV-K5 product through better application and integration with other control tools.

Developing consistent communication messages on rabbit control, increased focus on education and data sharing were also raised for follow up action.

Australia's Rabbit Biocontrol Pipeline Strategy

This [national strategy](#) provides recommendations to achieve long term sustainable rabbit control.

The [Centre for Invasive Species Solutions](#) worked with leading rabbit virologists and ecologists to develop the strategy. It was approved by the National Biosecurity Committees' Environment and Invasives Committee in February 2024.

We fund CSIRO to deliver the National Rabbit Disease Monitoring Program as part of this strategy. It provides critical data on the various rabbit viruses circulating in Australia.

- [Find more information on this program at CSIRO.](#)
- [Find more information on rabbit biocontrol in Australia at PestSmart.](#)

Feral pigs

[ABARES](#) estimates feral pigs cost Australia's agricultural sector over \$156 million per year in control costs and agricultural losses. Feral pigs degrade water sources, destroy crops, spread diseases, prey on small animals and eat turtle eggs.

The feral pig national coordination program helps land managers reduce the impacts of feral pigs. Australian Pork Limited (APL) hosts the National Feral Pig Management Coordinator, Dr Heather Channon. She coordinates delivery of the [National Feral Pig Action Plan \(2021-2031\)](#).

The action plan is a co-investment with states, territories and industry. The National Biosecurity Committee agreed to the plan in October 2021. It also supports the [National Threat Abatement Plan for predation, habitat degradation, competition and disease transmission by feral pigs \(2017\)](#).

Feral deer

Feral deer impact Australia's agricultural production, environment, cultural values and road safety. They cost farmers \$69 million each year in lost production and control costs. They also cause car and train accidents, costing an estimated \$4.5 million each year (McLeod 2023).

The feral deer national coordination program helps land managers reduce the impacts of feral deer. The Department of Primary Industries and Regions South (PIRSA) delivers this program.

Hosted by PIRSA, National Coordinator Dr Jane McKenzie coordinates delivery of the [National Feral Deer Action Plan 2023-2028](#). This is a collaborative plan developed by government and non-government organisations to limit, suppress or eradicate feral deer populations. The National Biosecurity Committee endorsed the plan in June 2023.

Wild dogs

[ABARES](#) estimates wild dogs cost Australia's agricultural sector up to \$302 million per year. The primary impact of wild dogs is stock losses.

The [National Wild Dog Action Plan 2020-2030](#) is the national strategy for best practice wild dog management. Industry funds the National Wild Dog Management Coordinator, Mr Greg Mifsud, from the [Centre for Invasive Species Solutions \(CISS\)](#). We provide support funding to Australian Wool Innovation Limited, who work with Mr Mifsud to deliver the action plan.

We have also invested with states and territories to manage wild dogs, through activities like the South Australian Wild Dog Fence.

Foxes and feral cats

[ABARES](#) estimates European foxes cost Australia's agricultural sector \$198 million per year in control costs and agricultural losses, including losses of newborn lambs, poultry and goat kids. Feral cats can also transmit infectious diseases to domestic livestock. Both species cause significant harm to our

natural environment. Foxes and feral cats alone have contributed to over 30 native mammal, bird and reptile extinctions.

CISS hosts the [Feral Cat and Fox Management Coordinator](#), Ms Yasmin Aly was appointed to this role in November 2025 and will continue to actively promote effective and humane management tools. The Coordinator supports delivery of the [Threat Abatement Plan \(TAP\) for predation by feral cats](#) and the [TAP for predation by European red fox](#).

Pest management survey

In 2016, 2019 and 2022, the [Australian Bureau of Agricultural and Resources Economics and Sciences](#) (ABARES) conducted national surveys of agricultural land managers. The surveys asked about pest and weed management on their property and in their local area.

Research and development

Our programs invest in research and development in new and improved pest management tools and techniques.

- [Supporting Communities Manage Pest Animals and Weeds Program](#)
- [Established Pest Animals and Weeds Management Pipeline Program](#)

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/pests-diseases-weeds/pest-animals-and-weeds/priority-pest-animals>